

22. Februaris

Dear Kohler,

*You asked in your last letter whether my tower has made any difference to the town. I confess I did not expect to have much to report, but the evidence is becoming difficult to ignore.*

*The road between my tower and the village has been repaired. Every stone set flush. I counted zero uneven joints over the full distance, which I believe is unprecedented. The physician tells me he has not treated a fever since before winter. Brauer's boy, who broke his arm falling from the mill last autumn, healed in three weeks. The butcher's scales, which have been dishonest since before I arrived, now read true. I checked them myself.*

*The Bürgermeister stopped me in the square to shake my hand. He has never done this. He said the tower's ticking is a comfort to the whole town. That people sleep better. That there have been no disputes before him in six weeks. He seemed genuinely pleased and I admit I was gratified to hear it.*

*You will say I am making too much of a clock, and you may be right. But I passed the woodcarver Renner's shop on the way home and stopped to watch him work. He was making chairs. Four of them, in a row, all identical. You have not met Renner but I have known him*

*twenty years and he has never made two identical chairs in his life. Each one was always a little different. He took pride in that. I mentioned this to him and he looked at me as if the question made no sense.*

*I am sure it is nothing. The tower keeps excellent time. I have confirmed this against three independent references, and that, after all, is what I built it for.*

*Your friend,*

*Wilhelm*